The dowager queen had three advisers, including Munim's brother and nephew, all of whom were killed in a churn of bloody intrigue. (Munim's nephew, for example, was invited to a drinking party, decapitated when drunk, and his body 'flung down from the citadel'.)[59] Her fourth adviser she may have married; he was allowed to live, at any rate, while he served as her son Hakim's vakil.[60]

It was in Hakim's name, and for his sake, that Mahchuchak did what she did. Merely being born in Kabul did not make it his; the city was as much in contention now as it had been when Humayun and Kamran fought over it. Within moments of Humayun's death, it would seem, Sulaiman of Badakhshan had marched upon the city, and though he was eventually dispatched by Munim, surely his wife Haram Begum's ambitions would send him marching this way again.

Across the Indus, meanwhile, Akbar's power was only increasing. Soon after executing Adham Khan, Akbar ordered Munim to recover Kabul and take charge of Hakim as his ataliq – guardian, tutor and mentor rolled into one. The news did not gladden Mahchuchak's heart: she had driven out Munim's son and presided over the brutal murders of his brother and nephew. She could hardly expect a warm reunion with her son's new adviser. Instead, therefore, she rode to war.

Munim Khan was defeated, comprehensively. Not only did he lose the battle, he lost many of his men to Mahchuchak's side, and most of his possessions – 30 lakh in cash according to a member of his retinue. It was only because the winning army was so busy with its loot, in fact, that Munim didn't lose his liberty, too, and escaped with his life.

Thus, tail between his legs, Munim Khan returned to Akbar's court; and Mahchuchak rode in triumph to Kabul. Unfortunately, this moment of great victory was also the beginning of her fall.

It came in the treacherously handsome form of Humayun's favourite sayyid, Shah Abul Ma'ali, last seen making a discreet exit from Hindustan after hiring a sniper to shoot Akbar down.

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It was around the time of Mahchuchak's victory that Sharafuddin and Abul Ma'ali had joined forces against Akbar – even pre-empting the Uzbeks' idea